

I recently participated in the Game Maker's Toolkit 2026 Game Jam as a solo developer. With around 10,500 entries, it was a huge event to take part in!

This is a fun little post-mortem reflecting on what I did, how the game turned out, and most of all, what I learnt from this experience.

TLDR: I made a silly cowboy game about cows having stopwatch duels in 3 days, and it did a lot better than I had expected. The big lessons I took away were that proper scoping is everything, simple mechanics can carry a game, and a little bit of personality can make even a small project stand out.

Quickly Drawn: <https://itch.io/jam/gmtk-jam-2026/rate/4819399>

What Was My Goal, and Was It Achieved?

From the start, I set a goal for myself that if I met, I would consider this a success, regardless of what score it got.

I decided to challenge something that I had failed to do in my previous game jam -

Scoping. Properly design, scope out and code a game within the 3 days, while going to bed at a reasonable hour. Additional points if I had fun all the way. (And I certainly did!)

How'd it go?

From previous experience, the biggest hurdle I had was scoping. Due to the time limit, and the fact that I was all alone, I ended up going for a rather simple base mechanic. From there, I set a specific task for each day of the game jam.

- **Day 1:** Designing the mechanic, setting up the Unity project and getting a basic prototype of the game.
- **Day 2:** Making content and basic UI for the game. Turning the prototype into an actual game.
- **Day 3:** Polish. Improving the UI, adding sounds, music, and ensuring the game has no bugs.

Honestly, this almost went perfectly... Until an incident happened on day 3, where it took 4 hours to build the project to send to Itch, essentially stopping any progress during that time. This resulted in a hard choice I had to make, to cut out music and audio entirely.

Despite this, the goals and time limits I set out for myself made sure that this didn't end up harming the submission, as I made sure to make the build much BEFORE the cutoff time.

The Idea

The theme for the jam was pretty simple - COUNTDOWN.

The theme helped narrow down the type of game I wanted to make - something simple that played to my strengths: games design and expanding upon simple ideas

I decided to take inspiration from a real-life activity:

A stopwatch.

Yes, it sounds silly and rather mundane - "Stop the clock when the timer gets to the number", but from that alone, there is a lot you can tweak or adjust, like what if the timer moved slower? What if the timer was rotating, or if the timer was in binary? Even aside from simply adjusting the timer itself or the flow of time, we can do things like making the player stop the time at intervals almost like a rhythm game, or have them deliberately fail in order to succeed.

It's because the concept is so easy to understand, we can skip right to adding interesting twists to the gameplay without sacrificing understanding.

From that, it was then a question of turning the concept into a game.

Rather than simply chasing a high score, I wanted every round to feel like a duel. The countdown became a standoff between two cow gunslingers, where the player had to decide when to draw and hope they were more accurate than their opponent.

From there, the game naturally split into two parts:

- **Attack phase:** The player attempts to stop the timer as close as possible to the target.
- **Defence phase:** The player attempts to reduce incoming damage by timing their defence correctly.

This created a simple risk/reward loop:

- Stop too early, or too late, and you deal weak damage. (Of course, it was a lot easier to hit these thresholds.)
- Get the timing perfect and you perform a "perfect draw", either dealing a ton of damage, or reducing all the damage to zilch.

From there, I had each cow opponent have pun abilities that either affected how the timer worked, or how the base game worked. An example was a Cyborg C0w, who turned the timer into binary, or a stealthy cow who hid the timer.

How'd it go?

To my complete shock, this went extremely well.

Quickly Drawn was ranked #1314 in Creativity, and #1416 for Enjoyment. (Essentially ranking in the top 14% of the jam for those 2 categories.) In fact, for all categories, except for Audio (which it scored terribly in on the account that it had no audio), it ranked above 2000. in a jam with 10.5k submissions, that blew my mind.

What I Learnt

1. Good Scoping is More than Cutting Features

Prior to this jam, I always saw good scoping as simply boiling an idea down to what is necessary and then executing it.

While that is a part of it, what I realized is that scoping is also about discipline. What needs to be done, by when, and how much time you reserve for unexpected errors.

Giving each day a specific purpose helped me hone down on what needed to be done, and more importantly helped me not stray from what was unfeasible. By day 3, I had a full game and could put all my attention into polishing rather than worrying about game systems or additional content, because that was already done.

The four hour build issue also demonstrated why this was important. If I had not finished the game by that point, I would not have had the time to respond to the issue. Even with the audio cut, the gameplay had been polished and finalised, and thus it was still complete and ready to submit.

2. 1 Simple Mechanic can Carry a Game

I was unsure whether or not something so small and simple could capture people's interests. However, this jam taught me something important - A game does not need complex mechanics, endless content, or hours of gameplay to be engaging.

Quickly Drawn is a very short game - only about 2-5 minutes long, however this ended up working to its favor. The core mechanic could be easily understood, explored, and delivered without overstaying its welcome.

The game focused on taking one simple idea and finding different ways to build upon it, and while the game was short, it showcased the potential of the mechanic and left room for players to imagine what else could be done with it.

It is often better to do one thing well than to do many things adequately.

3. A Game Needs a Soul

This one is a more subjective opinion, but I think a contributor to what let the game do as well as it did was personality.

The cowboys being literal cows started as a joke, but it quickly became one of the defining parts of the game. The silly names, cow puns, and the whole mood of the game gave it something more than just a “stopwatch game”.

More importantly, it was something I genuinely enjoyed making. That enjoyment naturally carried into the final product and made it something I could confidently share with other people.

It taught me that even with simple mechanics, the right dash of personality can make a game pop that much more.

Final Thoughts

Going into this jam, my goal was not to win or create the most impressive game. All I wanted to do was to prove that I could properly scope, complete, and enjoy making a game within a strict deadline.

Looking back, *Quickly Drawn* exceeded that goal. I now know that I can take an idea, scope it properly, execute it within a deadline and most importantly, have fun all the way through.

The rankings were an incredible surprise, but the biggest takeaway was learning that a small idea, when given enough focus and personality, can become something much more than I initially expected.

It turns out that sometimes, less is more!

Thanks for reading, and thanks to everyone who played, rated, or gave feedback on *Quickly Drawn*!